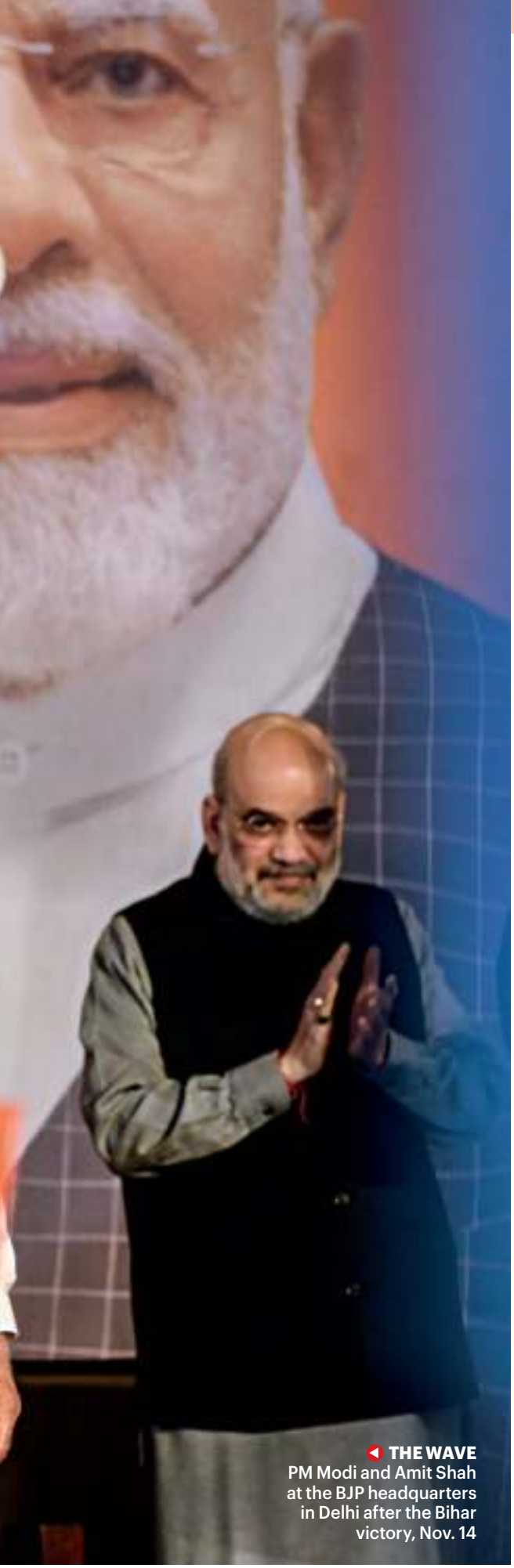
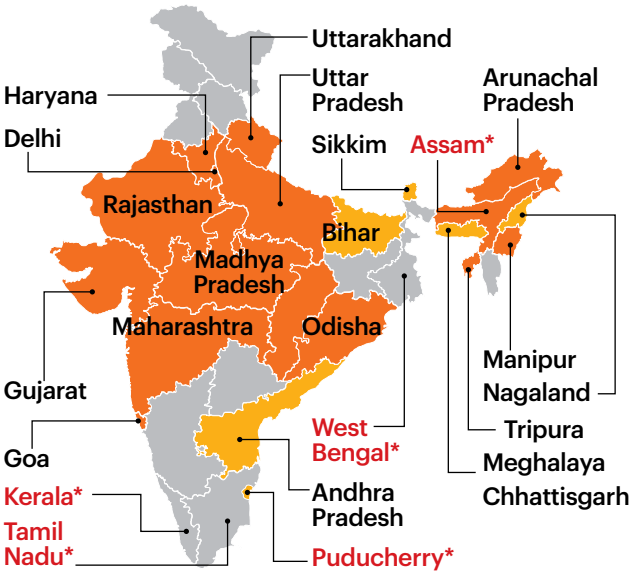


THE WAVE
PM Modi and Amit Shah at the BJP headquarters in Delhi after the Bihar victory, Nov. 14

THE SAFFRON SPREAD



BJP-ruled *NDA-ruled; *Upcoming elections*

the electoral momentum to create a fully aligned organisational structure. "Bihar gave us rhythm," says a senior BJP strategist. "Now Bengal will give us direction."

BATTLE FOR BENGAL

Bengal, however, is likely to test every election theory the party holds close to heart. In 2021, the Mamata Banerjee-led Trinamool Congress (TMC) swept the assembly election with 214 out of 294 seats and a 48 per cent vote share; the BJP got 77 seats with a 38.1 per cent vote share. That slipped marginally in the 2024 LS poll (39.1 per cent, against 40.6 per cent in 2019), shrinking its seat tally to 12 out of 42 from 18.

BJP insiders say there's no getting around it—their biggest hindrance in the state is the large concentration of Muslim populations in some districts. There are 146 assembly seats where the community accounts for 25-90 per cent of the voters. In 2021, the TMC won 131 of these seats, while the BJP won 14 and the remaining seat went to the Indian Secular Front (ISF).

The communal polarisation the party has relied on in past elections has only taken it so far in terms of vote share. "In fact, it has helped Mamata, as the Muslim votes moved en bloc to the TMC, while the BJP's reverse polarisation worked only in parts," says a state party veteran. With returns from its usual playbook diminishing, the BJP has dialled down the Hindutva rhetoric. In Maharashtra, Delhi and Bihar, poll results have shown that if the party hits a softer tone, the Muslim vote does look for alternatives. The party is hoping the scenario will play out in Bengal as well.

But then that comes up against a new political flashpoint. Since mid-October, the Election Commission's Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls has begun in Bengal. The final rolls are due by February 7. The BJP has seized on the process to strengthen its booth-level machinery and verify voter data, even as the TMC has stepped up warnings about voter names being deleted and begun accusing the EC of aiding a "political purge".